The workflow overview

Treat it like a bright new intern who has never worked here. Capable, fast, eager, and completely ignorant of how your office runs. Whatever you would tell that person is your prompt.

THE FIVE STEPS

1. **Name the task**
   One sentence. What the job is, and what you want to come out the other end.

2. **Write the context a new employee would need**
   The part everyone can be easy to skip, and the part that decides whether this actually works. Where the information lives, what the columns are called and in what order, what the values mean, what a normal example looks like. It cannot see your screen and it will not ask.

3. **Hand it over as instructions - as a first message, not a finished one**
   Every rule, including what to leave alone. Every guardrail, including what it must never do. Then send it, knowing it is wrong somewhere. This is the opening of an iterative conversation and it's extremely rare to get it perfect on the first try.

4. **Test it on an example where you already know the answer**
   Not a real one. A made-up one, small, where you can count the correct result before you run it. If you cannot tell right from wrong, you cannot tell working from broken.

5. **Read the result like an editor, then go back to step three**
   Tell it what it got wrong, in plain language, and paste the error if there is one. Then again. The loop is the method. Keep on iterating!

3 THINGS TO KEEP IN MIND

Your first message is a draft, and so is your understanding of your own process.

In my example: *I told it the report would arrive as a spreadsheet attachment. It built exactly that, flawlessly. There were no attachments. What I described was wrong.*

It does not know when it is wrong, and it never sounds like it.

In my example: *A report had a line reading "Total Records: 4." My script decided 4 was a student ID and went looking for the student named 4. Nothing in the output looked wrong.*

Small things can cause a script to break or not work as intended.

In my example: *Mine looked for unread emails. If anyone opened one on their phone first, that student's data was gone - silently. The code was fine. My assumption was not.*

Sensitive EMU work goes in Gemini - if anywhere at all. What matters is the data you are handing over, not the tool and not the task. Anything about a real person, or anything confidential to EMU, goes in Gemini signed in with your @emu.edu account - no other tools should receive this type of data about EMU. Signing in means you may; it never means you should.

The same five steps, inside one prompt

The Activity 1 prompt, cut apart. Nothing here is clever - it is somebody explaining their own job carefully to someone who has never done it.

1 Name the task

```
I use a Google Sheet to track students who each need to complete a requirement. I want a Google
Apps Script that decides who needs a reminder and writes the emails for me.
```

Two sentences. The situation, then the ask.

2 The context a new employee would need

```
The sheet has one tab called Roster with these columns in this order: Name, Email, Item needed,
Status, Due date, Reminders sent, Last reminder. Row 1 is headers. Status is one of Not started,
Started, or Complete. [...]

Here is a sample row so you can see the shape:
Avery Nolan | avery.nolan@example.com | Immunization record | Not started | 2026-08-01 | 0 |
(blank)
```

Column order, what the values mean, one invented row. Skip this and it guesses - confidently.

3 The rules, spelled all the way out

```
- If Status is Complete, skip the row.
- If the due date has not passed, skip the row.
- If past due and Reminders sent is 0, create a first reminder.
- If past due and Reminders sent is 1 and Last reminder was 7 or more days ago, create a second,
firmer reminder. [...]
```

Every branch, including the ones where the answer is do nothing. The rows you want left alone need a rule too.

3 The guardrails - what it must never do

```
- Create Gmail drafts. Do not send anything.
- After drafting, increase Reminders sent by one and put today's date in Last reminder.
- Add comments explaining what each section does, because I don't write code.
```

"Do not send anything" is the line between a mistake and an incident. And telling it who you are changes what comes back more than any wording trick.

4 Test it where you already know the answer

Your practice sheet has eight invented people. Four should get emails. Three should be skipped, and each of the three is skipped for a different reason. The answer key is on the session page. A script that skips them for the wrong reasons still looks like it worked, and that is the entire lesson.

5 Read it like an editor, then go back to step three

Wrong count? Nothing happened? It tried to send instead of draft? Say so, in plain language, and paste the error. Then run it again. Four rounds is normal. Ten is normal. Keep on iterating.